

{Q How will I know that my newborn baby is healthy?

Your baby's first cries will be a wonderful sound but, understandably, you will want to know she is in perfect health. It is reassuring to know that she will be thoroughly checked immediately after the birth, and have more checkups before leaving the hospital. These are noninvasive and effective in highlighting possible health problems.

The APGAR test

In the early 1950s, American obstetric anesthesiologist Virginia Apgar developed a simple five-measure test to assess the health of a baby minutes after birth. The test has been criticized for being too simple, but it remains one of the first assessments your baby will have—at one minute after birth, and then again at five minutes after birth.

THE APGAR SCORE

Virginia Apgar's surname is used as an acronym for the five measures in this test, which is done immediately after the birth. This is why you will sometimes see it written as APGAR:

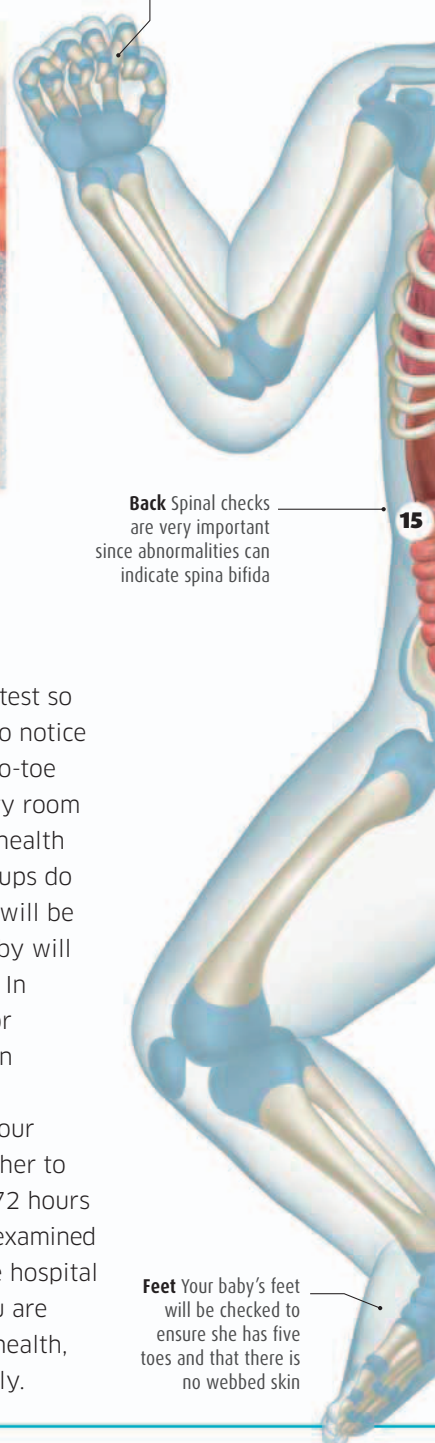
- » **Appearance:** Skin and lip color indicate whether your baby is getting enough oxygen.
- » **Pulse:** Your baby's heart rate is measured with a stethoscope.
- » **Grimace:** Your baby's response to stimuli, such as light or touch, will be checked.
- » **Activity:** Arm and leg movements give an indication of muscle tone.
- » **Respiration:** The rhythm and effort of your baby's breathing is checked.

After both the one-minute and five-minute check, a combined score of seven or more indicates that all is well. Between five and seven can mean the baby needs help breathing, but probably no more than a rub on the chest to kickstart her reflexes. A score of under five can indicate more help is needed, and a pediatrician will be called to examine the baby.

SCORE	0	1	2
Appearance Skin and lip color	Completely blue skin all over	Pink body with white or blue extremities	Completely pink skin all over
Pulse	No heartbeat	Slow heartbeat	Fast heartbeat
Grimace	Unresponsive	Reacts to stimulation	Crying spontaneously
Activity	Inactive, limp	Slow movements to extend and retract arms and legs	Lots of activity in the arms and legs
Respiration	No breathing	Slow, weak, or very uneven breathing	Strong breaths and crying



Grasp reflex You may be surprised by the strength of your newborn's grip. This is due to the grasp reflex; she will instinctively grasp something that is placed in her palm.



Hands The doctor will place a finger in your baby's palm to check that she grasps it

Back Spinal checks are very important since abnormalities can indicate spina bifida

Instant health checkup

Your doctor will do the Apgar test so quickly that you are unlikely to notice it is being done. Another top-to-toe check (see right) in the delivery room will highlight if there are any health concerns. If the doctor's checkups do highlight any problems, these will be explained to you, and your baby will be given the appropriate care. In some circumstances, the doctor may request that a pediatrician gives a second opinion.

Assuming all is well with your baby, you will be able to take her to the postpartum ward. Within 72 hours of the birth, your baby will be examined again (see p.246), either in the hospital or at home. If at any point you are concerned about your baby's health, inform your doctor immediately.

Feet Your baby's feet will be checked to ensure she has five toes and that there is no webbed skin